

Compiled brochure pages (in uploaded order)

Dr. C. Ramasubramanian, M.D., D.P.M., Ph.D.

A Profile

Dr. C. Ramasubramanian, widely known as Dr. CRS, has a comprehensive experience and expertise of 40 years in mental health services. He completed his undergraduate and post graduate medical education from Madurai Medical College and doctorate in community psychiatry from Madurai Kamaraj University in Tamil Nadu. He began his career in 1979 in Tamil Nadu Medical and Health Services where he was Professor and Head of Psychiatry at Madurai Medical College. His twin passions are community psychiatry and psychosocial rehabilitation.

The lived experience of caring for a brother with mental illness and the resulting stigma and discrimination experienced by the family sowed the seeds of Dr. Ramasubramanian's vision of comprehensive rehabilitation services for people with mental disabilities—a deep desire in the “wounded healer” to offer not just medicines to people with mental illness, but new hope... to answer what every parent of a person with mental illness often fears, “what will happen to our child after us?” ... to see persons with mental illness as assets to their families; not liabilities.

In the course of his professional career of over three decades in government service, Dr. Ramasubramanian was entrusted with several important responsibilities. He leveraged these opportunities to serve people with mental disabilities in the community through effective and efficient delivery of mental health services. He has been instrumental in making mental health care services available, affordable and accessible to people from the marginalized sections of society in Tamil Nadu.



Contributions towards mental health activism

His contributions as a mental health activist are significant in the following areas

- Enhancing awareness on mental health among the public;
- promoting and implementing community based psychiatric treatment and rehabilitation;
- enhancing human resource for quality mental health care delivery through capacity building of professionals; and
- spearheading advocacy and policy decisions in mental health.

Dr. Ramasubramanian's role as a champion for the welfare of people with mental disabilities also extends to the non-government sector. In 1992, in memory of his father MS. Chellamuthu, he established the M.S. Chellamuthu Trust and Research Foundation (MSCT&RF), a non-profit organization for mental health services, in Madurai, South India. The organization is a pioneer in mental health services and one of the largest psychosocial rehabilitation service providers in South Tamil Nadu.

Current positions

Dr. C. Ramasubramanian is currently

- Nodal Officer, Police Wellbeing Programme, Tamil Nadu
- President, World Association for Psychosocial Rehabilitation (WAPR), Indian Chapter
- Founder, M.S. Chellamuthu Trust and Research Foundation (MSCT & RF), Madurai
- Consultant Psychiatrist, Ahana Hospitals, Madurai



Experience and accomplishments

- State Nodal Officer, Mental Health Programme, Tamil Nadu (2008-2017)
- Expert Advisor, National Rural Health Mission, Tamil Nadu (2014-2017)
- Principal Investigator, National Mental Health Survey (2015), conducted by the Government of India in collaboration with the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS), Bengaluru.
- Technical Consultant for National Rural Health Mission, Tamil Nadu, for its Special Project on Development of a Comprehensive Programme for Children with Developmental Disorders in Dindigul District, Tamil Nadu.
- Principal Investigator (2015) in developing a need based model on Community Mental Health in India under the Asia Pacific Community Mental Health Development, a collaborative programme between India and Australia.
- Member, Welfare Board for the Disabled, Government of Tamil Nadu (2010-2013).
- Member, (Former), Academic Council of NIMHANS (Deemed University), Bengaluru.
- Member, Executive Council, Indian Association for Social Psychiatry.
- Chairperson, Community Psychiatry, South Zone, Indian Psychiatric Society (IPS).
- Chairperson, Psychiatric Rehabilitation Specialty Section, Indian Psychiatric Society.
- Secretary, District Mental Health Society, Madurai.
- President, Indian Association for the Blind, Madurai.

- Founder Member, M.S. Chellamuthu Trust & Research Foundation (MSCT&RF), Madurai.

Contributions to the welfare of people with mental disabilities

Government sector

- In recognition of his exemplary contribution to community mental health, Dr. Ramasubramanian was appointed State Nodal Officer for the Mental Health Programme of Tamil Nadu, which is currently being implemented in 25 districts in the state—the highest in the country. He has been appointed State Nodal Officer consistently for the past five years on extension service to coordinate the Mental Health Programmes of Tamil Nadu. The District Mental Health Programme (DMHP), acclaimed as one of the best in the country, provides comprehensive mental health care and has ensured basic psychiatric care in all the 12,000 villages in the state. There are about 12 lakh persons with mental illness and disabilities who have utilized the services of the DMHP.
- In a nationwide survey by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR 2010) on the overall satisfaction of the services provided for people with mental disabilities under the District Mental Health Programme, Tamil Nadu, especially Madurai, topped the list, scoring 9.6 out of 10. Madurai District has the distinction of providing highest quality mental health care services in the country.
- Dr. Ramasubramanian has been instrumental in establishing the District Level Special Board for the welfare of disabled population at the District Head Quarters Hospitals, Tamil Nadu.
- The District Mental Health Programme, Ramnad, was selected the Best Community Mental Health Project (rural) in India by the University of Melbourne, Australia. Currently this project has been selected for a collaborative programme between India and Australia.
- Dr. Ramasubramanian initiated the concept of inclusion of people with mental disabilities in the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee (MNREGA) Scheme year, a flagship welfare scheme of the Government of India. As a result of this unique initiative in the country, in every village in Tamil Nadu, people with mental



disabilities/care givers are assured work for at least 100 days in a year.

- Dr. Ramasubramanian is technical advisor for "Development of a Comprehensive Programme for Children with Developmental Disorders," in Dindigul District, Tamil Nadu, a project of National Rural Health Mission (NRHM), in collaboration with NIMHANS and MSCT&RF. MSCT & RF has conducted a household survey of 4,60,000 families and screened 88,000 children for disabilities.
- As the Secretary of Manasa District Mentally Disabled Welfare Agency, Madurai, Dr. Ramasubramanian has initiated the following activities:
 - District Disability Rehabilitation Centre (DDRC), Madurai
 - Suicide Prevention Counselling Centre, Madurai
 - Pudhu Vaazhvu Project, Madurai
- Dr. Ramasubramanian has initiated the process of establishing psychological counselling centres in all educational institutions in Madurai District to address the psychological problems of students. This was a leap forward in addressing the mental health of adolescents as part of community mental health initiatives. Teachers of 60 colleges in Madurai District were given a one-week training in psycho educational skills. Currently all educational institutions in Madurai district have three trained counselors equipped to effectively address psychological problems in the early stages.
- Dr. Ramasubramanian has started an innovative initiative, the Dava-Dua (Markkam-Maruthuvam) project at Erwadi, Ramanathapuram District in 2012. This novel initiative integrates religion in the

medical management of psychiatric illness—all under one roof. Patients from various parts of India flock to the dargah in Erwadi. Their first point of contact is the faith healers, who take them through the religious rites and then refer them to psychiatrists for treatment. Patients are examined by a team of qualified mental health practitioners in the dargah premises itself. The involvement of faith healers in the treatment process results in high patient compliance with treatment and satisfactory outcomes. Currently more than 3000 patients have benefited from the services.

- He has also initiated similar programmes with other religious faiths: at the famous St. Antony's church at Puliampatti Church, Thoothukudi; and at Sion Road with the help of Sathya Sai volunteers in Tamil Nadu.

Services offered by MSCT & RF

Awareness: Mental health literacy for the community and specific populations such as teachers, students, parents, health care professionals, traditional healers and caregivers.

Assessment & Training: Medical and psychosocial. This includes diagnosis and treatment, crisis intervention and referral services and counselling through out-patient and in-patient services and camps.

Rehabilitation: Skill Development and Livelihood Promotion

Training & Development: In order to develop human resources in the mental health sector, MSCT&RF launched the MRS Chellamuthu Institute of Mental Health and Rehabilitation in 2008 to strengthen competencies of mental health professionals. The institute offers postgraduate courses in counselling and psychotherapy in collaboration with Tamil Nadu Open University; and diploma in school counselling in collaboration with Alagappa University, Karaikal. Besides it offers internship programmes for students in various mental health disciplines, and weekend courses and seminars for corporates, homemakers and the general public on themes related to mental health.

Research: Studies on the impacts of Community Based Rehabilitation initiatives have been the focus of research activity among others areas.

Community mental health services

Non-government sector

Founder member, M.S.Chellamuthu Trust & Research Foundation (MSCT&RF)

Dr. Ramasubramanian established the M.S. Chellamuthu Trust and Research Foundation (MSCT&RF) in 1992 in response to widespread stigma and discriminatory attitudes towards mental illness, lack of awareness, inadequacy both in human resource and mental health care services in Tamil Nadu. With a vision of mental health for all, the trust promotes holistic mental health care that is available, accessible and affordable. For more than two decades, MSCT&RF is the largest mental health services provider in south Tamil Nadu.

Rehabilitation Services

At MSCT&RF, rehabilitation services are designed to promote recovery from mental disability and foster integration with society. A passionate commitment to honour and respect the dignity and humanity of the patients forms the core of the rehabilitation vision of MSCT&RF. Spurred by a belief that recovery from mental disability is everybody's business, the rehabilitation services work closely with the patient, the family and mental health professionals to add more meaning, purpose and satisfaction to the patient's life. MSCT&RF also provides community mental health services at the doorstep of people living in rural areas that have been selected for provision of such services. In rural areas, having a mentally ill person in the family results in several crushing burdens. Among them are lack of access to appropriate treatment facilities, loss of a day's income in accompanying patients for treatment and poor transport facilities.

The trust offers comprehensive rehabilitation services for diverse population groups such as:

- Children
- Adult
- Elderly
- Homeless persons with mental illness

The services include Institution Based Rehabilitation (IBR), Community Based Rehabilitation (CBR) and Support Services.

Institution Based Rehabilitation

a) Centre for rehabilitation of persons with mental illness

- Bodhi and Shristi (Short term Care Centres)
- Retreat (Long Term Care Centre)
- Vriksha (Rehabilitation Centre for Women)
- Rescue home and rehabilitation centre for homeless persons with mental disabilities

b) Centre for rehabilitation of persons with mental retardation

- Akaash (for differently abled children)
- Centre for rehabilitation of differently abled adults

c) Centre for rehabilitation of persons dependent on alcohol and drugs

- Trishul

d) Livelihood initiatives

- Centre for Vocational Rehabilitation and Placement
- Dairy Farming rehabilitation and Agro-based rehabilitation

Community Based Rehabilitation

a) The Community Mental Health Project (since 2000, supported by Andheri Hilfe, Germany)

b) Bridging mental health and religion (Community partnership of Mental health professionals and Faith healers)

- Monthly community mental health camp at Sivakasi in collaboration with volunteers of the Sathya Sai Samiti, Sivakasi (since 2001)

- Dava (medicine) and Dua (prayer) project in Erwadi, Ramnad District (since 2012)

Support Services

a) Subitcham (Caregivers' network)

b) Synergy (Siblings' network)

c) Share (Mental health volunteers network)

d) Legal aid services (Free legal consultations on rights, support and protection to persons with mental disabilities)



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- Dr. C. Ramasubramanian

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- Dr. K.S. Sanjivi Lifetime Achievement Award (2013) from Ekam Foundation and Udhavam Ullangal, Chennai, for undying devotion to the provision of healthcare to the underprivileged.
- District Best Doctor Award (2007) from the District Collector, Madurai District, Tamil Nadu, for outstanding services to the community in Madurai District.



Inspired and guided by Dr. Ramasubramanian, M.S. Chellamuthu Trust and Research Foundation was the recipient of several prestigious awards:

- District Level Best Non Governmental Organization, 1997, Madurai District Administration, Madurai.
- Best NGO in the state, 1996-97, Government of Tamil Nadu.

- Nation's Best Institution Award for the Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities 2007, Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, New Delhi.



- Nation's Best Individual Award 2008 awarded to Bharathi, beneficiary of the trust, by National Trust, New Delhi.



- Nation's Best Employee Award (1999-2000) awarded to Manoharan, beneficiary of the trust, by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Government of India.



legal support and protection to persons with mental disabilities.

A panel of lawyers supported by para legal volunteers provide professional expertise on several complex issues faced by persons with mental disabilities and their families such as guardianship, property rights, divorce, institutional care for destitute persons with mental illness and family pension. Since inception in 2009, 600 persons with mental disabilities have availed the legal services.

As part of his effort towards inclusion of people with mental disabilities, Dr Ramasubramanian has spearheaded a convergence of social assistance /welfare schemes of the government through advocacy efforts that highlighted the need for such schemes to also be applicable to people with mental disabilities. As a result of such policy initiatives currently, in Tamil Nadu, people with mental disabilities are eligible to avail the benefits of a flagship welfare scheme that assures a minimum of 100 working days wages for beneficiaries. As a special concession, people with mental disabilities are accorded flexible working hours in this welfare scheme.

Another policy initiative is an exclusive focus on persons with mental disabilities that addresses their specific mental health needs that is being integrated in the World Bank supported development program in the state. The impacts of the programme include awareness of mental health, wider reach of treatment services through camp approach, livelihood initiatives and formation of federations of caregivers.

Firm in his commitment in raising awareness and building a community of hope for people with mental disabilities, Dr. Ramasubramanian is a passionate advocate of their employability. Employment has been widely recognized as a fundamental part of recovery and of community integration for people with serious mental illness. Most importantly, work offers hope, which is vital to recovery from mental illness.

According to Dr. Ramasubramanian, people with mental disabilities are not "waste baskets." On the contrary, they have abilities and therefore there is a need to create suitable opportunities for employment that would enable them live with dignity and respect. Hence MSCT&RF has invested in several vocational strategies that enhance employability of people with mental disabilities such as sensitizing potential employers and training and placement of people with mental disabilities. In the last two decades, the

trust has successfully identified job placements for 6000 people with mental disabilities who have recovered.

Awards and Recognitions

In recognition of his service in the fields of mental health and community psychiatry, Dr. Ramasubramanian is the recipient of the following awards:

- V.R. Krishna Iyer Award (2016) for Social Justice and Human Rights Crusade, instituted by Society for Community Organization (SOCO) Trust, Madurai. Presented on January 26, 2016 by Hon'ble Justice D. Murugesan, Member, National Human Rights Commission, New Delhi.
- Vocational Excellence Award (2015) by Rotary International District 3000 on October 17, 2015.
- Abdul Kalam Seva Ratna Awards (2015) by Dr. Abdul Kalam Vision India Movement in recognition of outstanding service provided in the field of De-addiction on November 11, 2015, presented by His Holiness the Dalai Lama.



- Best Social Worker Award (2014) for services to the disabled population, presented by the State Bank of India, Chennai.
- District Best Doctor Award (2003) from the District Collector, Ramanathapuram District, Tamil Nadu, for yeomen service to the disabled persons.
- State Best Doctor Award (1999-2000) from the Government of Tamil Nadu for outstanding services to the rehabilitation of the disabled.
- Visakha Psychiatric Society Oration Award (2001) from the Indian Psychiatric Society, South Zone, for commitment to the field of community based rehabilitation.

Against All Odds

Nallamal (64) redefines motherhood in every sense of the term. If being the mother of a daughter with a mental challenge is difficult, Nallamal takes care of her four children with mental challenges with rare compassion and courage.

Poverty and gender disparities heighten the burden of mental disability. Married at the age of 13 years, Nallamal's husband was an agricultural labourer who worked for daily wages. However, he was severely depressed and early in the marriage, Nallamal was forced to take on the role of a caregiver that continued until his death a few years back.



Picture Courtesy: The Hindu, Metroplus Madurai Edition, Published on December 23, 2011

To add to her burdens, her two daughters Dhanalakshmi and Dhanam were diagnosed with borderline mental retardation. In addition, her two sons Murugesan and Balakrishnan were victims of substance abuse and developed severe psychosis as a result—all of which was undiagnosed initially. Amidst this vulnerable and highly volatile family environment, her eldest daughter Lakshmi was the only healthy person in the family. She supported the family by working as a nurse in a city hospital. However, about 20 years back Lakshmi committed suicide early in life, unable to bear the taunts of her in-laws for coming from a family of persons with mental illness.

However, it was Lakshmi who brought her mother and brothers into contact with MS Chellamuthu Trust and Research Foundation (MSCT&RF) in Madurai. Dr. C. Ramasubramanian, psychiatrist and founder of the trust, adopted the family and began to treat the brothers. In addition, Dhanam and Dhanalakshmi were also employed in the trust. However, the brothers discontinued treatment and even ran away from the centre. In the meanwhile, Dhanalakshmi, who began to show signs of improvement after treatment, took up employment in a textile mill in the city. However, tragedy struck again when she lost her leg in an on-site industrial accident. MSCT&RF interceded to meet Dhanalakshmi's treatment cost, supported her recovery and rehabilitation (getting her fitted with prosthesis) and also facilitated the legal process in the Labour Court that helped her avail the compensation.

Aware of the turbulent atmosphere at home, Nallamal made a conscious decision to keep her four children in different places and divides her time between them. The two sisters currently live in the home for mentally challenged persons run by MSCT&RF, and one of the sons stays with his mother near the home.

"Sometimes it's hard to be their mother. I know they will never have a normal life. But I cannot abandon them and I often remind them that as long as I am alive I will be there for them," says Nallamal as she highlights the essence of grace under immense pressure.

Nallamal says that her biggest blessing is the unconditional love and support she has been receiving from Dr. C. Ramasubramanian and his team.



Impacts of Dr Ramasubramanian's interventions in mental health Awareness

The most tangible impacts of Dr. C. Ramasubramanian's interventions in rehabilitation of persons with mental disabilities are significant shifts in public perceptions and attitudes towards people with mental illness. In contrast to the earlier pervasive stigma and discriminatory attitudes, currently there is visibility and space for people with mental disabilities. This has largely been due to systematic awareness and sensitization programmes for the community that is being undertaken by MSCT & RF since inception. These include consistent engagement through mental health literacy with different stakeholders such as teachers, students, parents, health care professionals, traditional healers and caregivers. This has resulted in considerable shift towards "normalization" of mental illness as treatable, curable and to some extent preventable if the illness is identified early, treatment initiated quickly and followed by appropriate rehabilitation.

Treatment and Rehabilitation

The treatment facilities through institutional care and community outreach in the form of mental health camps and community mental health has ensured that high quality mental health services based on factors such as equity, coverage, cost effectiveness and sustainability is made available at the doorstep of those segments of the rural population who are most in need of such services.

In addition to institution based rehabilitation services,

the trust has created participatory, community-led, community based rehabilitation services in specific areas of the state. These services are run by the family federations, supported with technical inputs from MSCT&RF.

Dava and Dua, the community mental health intervention that integrates religion and mental health has had several sustained impacts. The involvement of faith healers, who serve as ambassadors of mental health care, has underscored the fact that religious faith and mental health are not competitive and antagonistic; but rather complementary and compatible with each other.

The various support services for families and caregivers of people with mental disabilities has enabled them to be informed caregivers who blend the scientific and the personal elements in the challenging task of caring for person with mental disabilities. The regular meetings and sharing of experiences has helped them realize that they are not alone, but their shared experiences draw them together in a spirit of fellowship. Such informed care giving that respects the human rights of persons with mental disabilities has also enabled them to move towards self-reliance and independence because of a stable family environment.

The rescue and rehabilitation initiative of the trust addresses the basic needs of homeless persons with mental illness and enables them to live a life of dignity and respect. The stigma surrounding mental illness and the high cost of treatment often force several families to abandon mentally ill family members—often at pilgrim centres. These people are thus rejected both by their families and society. In several instances, affected persons also wander out of their homes on their own and are unable to be traced by the families.

Since its inception in 2009, the three centres have rescued and rehabilitated 2000 abandoned persons with mental illness provided them treatment, food, clothes and shelter and reunited them with their families.

Human Rights, Advocacy and Social Inclusion

Another tangible impact is recognizing and validating the human rights of people with mental disabilities through the legal aid services of MSCT & RF that is offered free of charge. The Centre for Legal Assistance run by the trust sensitizes stakeholders about the rights of people with mental disabilities and provides